

Flight Nurse Operations

Medivac.ai Platform

Clinical operations, patient transport, equipment management and documentation for Flight Nurses and Senior Flight Nurses.

Document SOP-CLN-001

DOCUMENT ID	SOP-CLN-001	ORGANISATION	RFDS South Eastern Section
VERSION	Draft 1	OWNER	Director of Clinical Services
ISSUE DATE	July 2026	AUTHOR	Perplexity Computer
CLASSIFICATION	Clinical (CLN)	STATUS	Uncontrolled when printed
REVIEW DUE	July 2027		

Document Control

This Standard Operating Procedure (SOP) is a controlled clinical document of the Royal Flying Doctor Service (RFDS) South Eastern Section. It describes how Flight Nurses and Senior Flight Nurses use the Medivac.ai platform across the aeromedical mission lifecycle. Printed copies are uncontrolled; always refer to the current electronic version in Medivac.ai.

Version	Date	Author	Description
Draft 1	July 2026	Perplexity Computer	Initial draft for clinical review.

Approvals

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1 Purpose and Scope

This SOP defines how RFDS South Eastern Section Flight Nurses and Senior Flight Nurses use the Medivac.ai platform to support clinical operations, patient transport, medical equipment management, and clinical documentation. Medivac.ai is the single system of record for the clinical elements of aeromedical missions, integrating dispatch and intake, equipment status, stock and consumables, telehealth, after-hours clinical decision support, and the passenger manifest.

1.1 Purpose

The purpose of this procedure is to ensure consistent, safe, and auditable clinical practice by standardising the way nursing staff interact with Medivac.ai throughout the mission lifecycle — from pre-mission preparation, through in-flight care, to post-mission handover and documentation.

1.2 Scope

This SOP applies to:

- All Flight Nurses employed or contracted by RFDS South Eastern Section.
- All Senior Flight Nurses acting as clinical leads on retrievals.
- Nurses undertaking the Ordering Nurse function for stock and equipment.
- Clinical operations conducted across fixed-wing aeromedical retrieval, inter-hospital transfer, and primary evacuation tasking.

This SOP does not replace clinical guidelines, the RFDS Clinical Manual, or manufacturer instructions for individual medical devices. Where a conflict exists, clinical guidelines and manufacturer instructions prevail, and the discrepancy must be reported to the Director of Clinical Services.

1.3 Definitions

Term	Definition
Medivac.ai	The integrated aeromedical operations platform used as the system of record for clinical, equipment, stock and manifest data.
Mission record	The electronic record within Medivac.ai holding all clinical, operational and equipment data for a single tasking.
FRMS	Fatigue Risk Management System governing duty and rest for crew and clinical staff.
Cold chain	The temperature-controlled supply and transport process for temperature-sensitive medications.
AI Med Line	The after-hours artificial-intelligence clinical decision support service available within Medivac.ai.

2 Roles and Responsibilities

Clinical accountability on every mission rests with the assigned nursing staff. The following roles define the division of clinical, mentoring and logistics responsibilities. All roles are recorded against the mission record in Medivac.ai.

2.1 Flight Nurse

The Flight Nurse is the primary clinical escort for the patient. Core responsibilities include:

- Conducting patient assessment at intake, pre-departure, and throughout the flight.
- Delivering in-flight clinical care within scope of practice and endorsement.
- Verifying that required medical equipment is serviceable and available before departure via the Medical Equipment module.
- Completing clinical entries on the passenger manifest and documenting interventions in the mission record.
- Escalating clinical concerns to the Senior Flight Nurse or via the After-Hours AI Med Line where indicated.

2.2 Senior Flight Nurse

The Senior Flight Nurse is the clinical lead and provides oversight for complex and high-acuity tasking. Core responsibilities include:

- Acting as clinical lead on complex retrievals and multi-patient tasking.
- Providing clinical supervision, mentoring and support to junior staff.
- Reviewing and endorsing clinical decisions and escalation pathways.
- Confirming currency and competency of the nursing team assigned to a mission.
- Leading clinical incident review and contributing to governance processes.

2.3 Ordering Nurse

The Ordering Nurse is responsible for stock ordering and equipment management across the base. Core responsibilities include:

- Managing consumable stock levels and raising orders in the Stock Usage & Orders module.
- Monitoring reorder thresholds and responding to low-stock alerts.
- Coordinating cold-chain medication storage, rotation and transport.
- Maintaining the register of medical equipment and its service status.

Activity	Flight Nurse	Senior Flight Nurse	Ordering Nurse
Patient assessment & in-flight care	R	A	–
Complex / high-acuity retrievals	C	R / A	–
Junior staff mentoring	–	R	–
Equipment serviceability check	R	A	C
Stock ordering & consumables	C	C	R / A
Clinical incident reporting	R	A	I

R = Responsible · A = Accountable · C = Consulted · I = Informed

3 Pre-Mission Clinical Workflow

The pre-mission workflow ensures the nursing team is clinically and logistically prepared before departure. Each step below is completed and recorded within Medivac.ai against the mission record.

3.1 Dispatch & Intake

On tasking, review the intake record in Medivac.ai. Confirm patient details, provisional diagnosis, clinical priority, and any special clinical requirements (for example, isolation, bariatric handling, or paediatric considerations). Verify the receiving and referring facility details and estimated times.

3.2 Medical Equipment

Using the Medical Equipment module, confirm that all equipment required for the clinical profile of the patient is present, serviceable, charged and within calibration. Any equipment flagged out-of-service must not be loaded, and a serviceable replacement must be sourced before departure.

3.3 Stock Usage & Orders

Confirm that consumables and medications required for the mission are stocked and in date. Where the mission profile indicates additional or specialised consumables, verify availability through the Stock Usage & Orders module and escalate shortfalls to the Ordering Nurse.

3.4 Telehealth Portal

Where indicated by acuity or clinical uncertainty, conduct a pre-retrieval video assessment of the patient through the Telehealth Portal. Record the assessment outcome, any clinical instructions, and informed consent in the mission record.

3.5 After-Hours AI Med Line

For unusual or complex presentations outside standard hours, the After-Hours AI Med Line provides clinical decision support. It is an aid to — not a replacement for — clinical judgment and escalation to a medical officer where required.

3.6 Passenger Manifest

Complete the clinical entries for the patient on the passenger manifest, including weight, mobility, clinical escort requirements, and any carriage restrictions. Ensure the manifest reconciles with the operational load sheet prior to departure.

PRE-DEPARTURE CLINICAL CHECK

No aeromedical mission departs until the assigned nurse has confirmed intake review, equipment serviceability, consumable stock, and manifest completion in Medivac.ai. Unresolved items are escalated to the Senior Flight Nurse.

4 In-Flight Clinical Documentation

Medivac.ai supports documentation of clinical interventions performed during the flight. The primary clinical priority in flight is patient care; documentation should not compromise the delivery of clinical interventions.

Clinical notes should be entered in the mission record as soon as practicable post-flight, capturing an accurate, contemporaneous account of the patient's condition and the care provided. Where clinically significant events occur in flight, brief contemporaneous notes (for example, timestamps of interventions, medication administration, and observations) should be captured to support accurate reconstruction of the clinical timeline.

Documentation entered into Medivac.ai must be accurate, objective, and attributable. Entries are date- and time-stamped and linked to the documenting clinician.

Documented in flight / post-flight	Where recorded
Patient observations and trends	Mission record – clinical notes
Medication administration	Mission record – medication log
Clinical interventions and procedures	Mission record – clinical notes
Consumables and medications used	Stock Usage & Orders
Clinical events or deterioration	Mission record + incident log

CONTEMPORANEOUS RECORD

Clinical documentation is a professional and medico-legal obligation. Complete the mission record as soon as practicable and never retrospectively alter an entry — use an addendum where correction is required.

5 Post-Mission Documentation

Post-mission activities close the clinical and logistics loop for the tasking. All items below are completed in Medivac.ai before the nurse signs off the mission.

5.1 Clinical Handover Notes

Document a clear clinical handover in the mission record, summarising presentation, interventions, response to treatment, and any outstanding clinical actions communicated to the receiving facility.

5.2 Medical Equipment Return-to-Service Check

Complete a return-to-service check for all equipment used. Confirm cleaning, function, charge status and calibration in the Medical Equipment module, and flag any device requiring maintenance.

5.3 Stock Usage Recording

Record all consumables and medications used during the mission in the Stock Usage & Orders module. Accurate recording maintains stock accuracy and triggers reorder thresholds where applicable.

5.4 Incident or Clinical Event Documentation

Where a clinical incident, near miss, or notable clinical event occurred, complete an incident record in Medivac.ai and notify the Safety Officer in accordance with Section 8.3.

Post-mission task	Module	Responsible
Clinical handover notes	Mission record	Flight Nurse
Equipment return-to-service	Medical Equipment	Flight Nurse
Stock usage recording	Stock Usage & Orders	Flight Nurse / Ordering Nurse
Incident / clinical event	Incident log	Flight Nurse / Senior FN

6 Equipment Management

Medical equipment is managed through the Medical Equipment module in Medivac.ai, which provides a single register of devices, their service status, and calibration records.

6.1 Medical Equipment Module

Daily equipment checks are recorded in the Medical Equipment module. Each check confirms device presence, function, charge status, and calibration currency. Checks are attributed to the completing clinician and time-stamped.

6.2 Critical Devices

The following critical devices require documented checks before each mission and at defined intervals:

Device	Key checks
Defibrillator	Self-test pass, pad expiry, battery charge, ECG function.
Ventilator	Circuit integrity, alarm test, gas supply, battery backup.
Infusion pump	Battery charge, occlusion alarm, calibration currency.
Oxygen cylinder	Cylinder pressure, regulator function, secure mounting, expiry.

6.3 Out-of-Service Equipment

Any device that fails a check, is damaged, or is beyond calibration must be flagged out-of-service in Medivac.ai and engineering notified. Out-of-service devices are quarantined and must not be used clinically until returned to service.

DO NOT USE FLAGGED EQUIPMENT

Equipment flagged out-of-service in Medivac.ai must never be loaded or used on a mission. Source a serviceable replacement and escalate to the Senior Flight Nurse if none is available.

7 Stock and Consumables

Stock and consumables are managed through the Stock Usage & Orders module. Accurate stock management ensures mission readiness and medication integrity.

7.1 Ordering Nurse Responsibilities

The Ordering Nurse maintains base stock levels, raises and tracks orders, and ensures consumables and medications are in date and correctly stored. The Ordering Nurse reconciles recorded usage against physical stock on a routine basis.

7.2 Reorder Thresholds and Alerts

Reorder thresholds are configured per item in Medivac.ai. When stock falls to or below the threshold, an alert is generated for the Ordering Nurse to raise a replenishment order. Alerts must be actioned promptly to avoid stock-outs of mission-critical items.

7.3 Cold-Chain Medications

Temperature-sensitive medications are stored and transported within the cold chain. Storage temperatures are monitored and logged, and any excursion is recorded and the affected stock quarantined pending assessment.

Requirement	Standard
Storage temperature	Maintained within manufacturer-specified range; continuously monitored.
Transport	Validated cold-chain carriers; temperature logged for the duration of transport.
Excursion handling	Quarantine affected stock; record excursion; assess before use or disposal.
Documentation	Temperature logs retained and linked to the relevant stock records.

8 Clinical Governance

Clinical governance ensures that the use of Medivac.ai supports safe, accountable clinical practice consistent with RFDS clinical standards.

8.1 After-Hours AI Med Line

The After-Hours AI Med Line provides clinical decision support and is not a substitute for clinical judgment. Nurses remain accountable for clinical decisions and must escalate to a medical officer where the presentation exceeds scope or where clinical uncertainty persists.

8.2 Telehealth Protocols

Telehealth assessments require informed consent, which must be obtained and documented in the mission record. The clinical content, participants, and outcomes of the telehealth interaction are documented consistent with standard clinical record-keeping.

8.3 Clinical Incident Reporting

Clinical incidents, near misses, and adverse events are reported through the incident function in Medivac.ai, with notification to the Safety Officer. Reports support review, learning, and continuous improvement under the clinical governance framework.

Severity	Action	Notification
No harm / near miss	Record incident in Medivac.ai.	Safety Officer
Minor harm	Record incident; clinical review.	Safety Officer + Senior FN
Moderate / major harm	Record incident; escalate immediately.	Safety Officer + Director of Clinical Services

9 Fatigue and Wellbeing

Fatigue is a recognised clinical and aviation safety risk. Nursing staff are subject to fatigue management arrangements aligned with those of flight crew.

9.1 Duty & FRMS

Nurses track duty hours in Medivac.ai in the same manner as flight crew, within the Fatigue Risk Management System (FRMS). Duty and rest periods are monitored to manage cumulative fatigue.

9.2 RFDS Nurses EBA 2023 Provisions

Duty, rest and fatigue arrangements for nursing staff are applied consistent with the provisions of the RFDS Nurses Enterprise Bargaining Agreement (EBA) 2023. Where the EBA and this SOP differ on duty limitations, the EBA prevails.

9.3 Self-Declaration of Fatigue

Nurses have a personal and professional obligation to self-declare fatigue. Where a nurse assesses that fatigue may impair safe clinical performance, they must notify the Dispatcher without delay so that the tasking can be reassessed.

OBLIGATION TO SELF-DECLARE

Self-declaration of fatigue is a safety-critical responsibility. A nurse who is unfit due to fatigue must notify the Dispatcher and must not commence or continue a tasking until the risk is managed.

10 Currency and Training

Maintaining clinical currency and completing required training is a condition of continued operational assignment. Currency and training records are held in Medivac.ai.

10.1 Check & Training Module

The Check & Training module records clinical currency, competencies, and endorsements. Nurses are responsible for maintaining RFDS clinical currency, and the Senior Flight Nurse confirms team currency before assignment to a mission.

10.2 Annual Competency Assessments

Annual competency assessments are scheduled and recorded in the Check & Training module. Lapsed competencies are flagged, and staff with lapsed currency are not rostered to affected clinical duties until currency is restored.

Requirement	Frequency	System of record
Clinical currency review	Ongoing	Check & Training
Annual competency assessment	Annual	Check & Training
Endorsement verification	Per assignment	Check & Training
Duty / fatigue tracking	Per duty period	FRMS (Medivac.ai)

End of document. This SOP is maintained by the Director of Clinical Services and is reviewed as part of the RFDS South Eastern Section clinical governance cycle. Refer to the current electronic version in Medivac.ai; printed copies are uncontrolled.